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1. Looking at the letters in the order in which they appear in KRYPTOS, the KR and YP read left to right, while SO reads right to left. Maybe they indicate the direction that text should be put in to (or taken out of) a matrix. First row – left to right, second row – right to left, third row left to right.
2. KRSOYP (or KRSOTYP) could be a key indicating the order in which columns need to be rearranged, either moving them into KRYPTOS order or, more likely, alphabetical order.
3. Or, just as the raised letters and the grouping in Part 3 provided two clues, maybe the KR SO YP provides both the direction of the text *and* the order for manipulating the rows.

The Cipher Text, at this point.

Regardless of the meaning of the clue, the letters KR, SO, and YP are not part of the message. So the text now reads:

?OBUO XOGHU LBSOL IFBBW FLRVQ QPRNG
 KS**T**WT QSJQS SEKZZ WATJK LUDIA WINFB
 NVTTM ZFPKW GDKZX TJCDI GKUHU AUEKC AR

Again, note that T (shown in red) may or may not be part of the message.

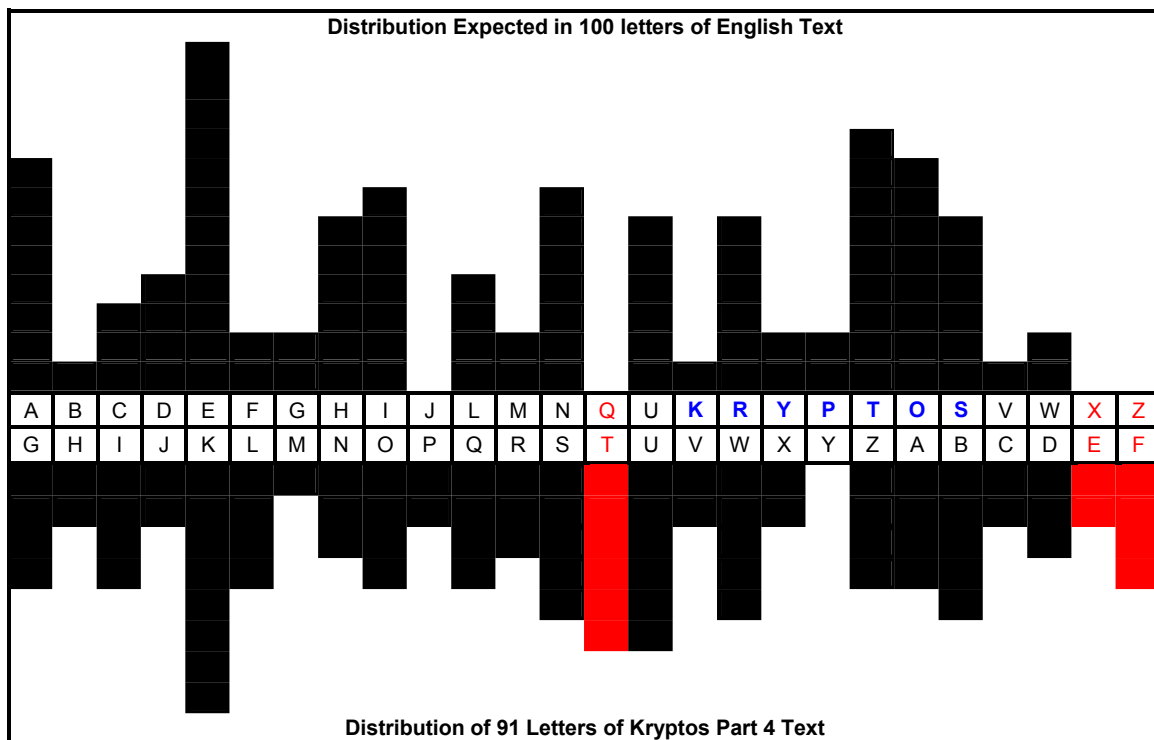
The Substitution

The substitution seems surprisingly straightforward. While the IC (Index of Coincidence) produced by the text would seem to rule out a simple substitution in the English language, it should be kept in mind that Scheidt clearly said the message was in English and implied that something might have been done to hide that fact.

There is a very simple technique that is used to solve Caesar ciphers – messages encrypted by simply shifting one alphabet relative to another. You graph the frequency distribution of English on one piece of paper and the frequency distribution of the message on another and simply slide them relative to each other until you find a good match. The match, when found, is usually quite obvious.

Through a process of trial and error, using a number of obvious alphabets (straight, reversed, KRYPTOS in one or both, etc.), I eventually found a match that seemed just too good to be true. Given the small size of the sample, the match was absolutely stunning – certainly as good as you would expect to find in a simple Caesar of similar length.

The match is shown in the graph below. Ignore the RED bars for now; they will be explained shortly.



The evidence that this is the correct substitution is, in my opinion, overwhelming:

1. The matches in the peaks and valleys are quite dramatic – especially considering the small size of the sample.
2. The alphabets seem quite appropriate for this puzzle and not in the least bit contrived. The first is simply an alphabet with the word KRYPTOS inserted right after the QU. While the other is a straight alphabet, slightly shifted.
3. Even three of the anomalies, the QT, XE and ZF pairings add credibility to the match. One technique to make the text “look less like English” would be the addition of low frequency letters. Q was already used as a null at the end of Part 3. X has been used in previous sections as a paragraph break. If the goal was to lower the IC, then it would make sense to spread the nulls among several low frequency letters. Z would be a natural choice.

Other Evidence?

This is a bit more speculative, but if we were to look back at earlier sections for clues that *might* provide an operative with the information necessary to construct these alphabets we find:

1. The K and R spelling errors in Parts 1 & 2. These correspond to Q and U in the plain text. In our first alphabet, KRYPTOS is inserted right after the QU.

2. The one alphabet in the table side of KRYPTOS that contains an extra letter at the end is the line starting GHI... that starting point for our shifted alphabet.

The Text After the Substitution

After making the substitution the text becomes:

?ISUI YIABU FSNIF CZSSR ZFMKL LJMHA
EN^QRQ LNDLN NXETT ROQDE FUWCO RCHZS
HKQQG TZJER AWETY QDVWC AEUBU OUXEV OM

Keep in mind that the Q (shown in red) corresponds to the T that may or may not be part of the message.

Are the Q and Z nulls deliberately paired with KRYPTOS letters?

I spent a great deal of time working with transpositions that would result in the nulls all falling at the end of the message (with little luck, I might add).

But, what would happen if the nulls had been randomly placed within the text? The first problem is that the operative would have to have some tool that would let him or her determine which Q and/or Z was a null and which was part of the message.

This is where another amazing “coincidence” occurs.

?ISUI YIABU FSNIF **CZSSR** **Z**FMKL LJMHA
EN^Q**RQ** LNDLN NXETT **ROQ**DE FUWCO RCH**ZS**
HKQQG **TZ**JER AWETY **Q**DVWC AEUBU OUXEV OM

Eight of the ten “nulls” are directly paired with letters in the word KRYPTOS. And even the remaining two are adjacent to such pairs.

I can imagine a “rule” for placing the nulls that goes something like this:

Place each null directly adjacent to a KRYPTOS letter. This will allow the operative to identify the nulls and drop them from the message.

Following that rule, we can now drop any single null that is paired with a KRYPTOS letter. This still leaves two ambiguous areas:

?ISUI YIABU FSNIF C SSR FMKL LJMHA
ENQRQ LNDLN NXETT RO DE FUWCO RCH S
HKQQG T JER AWETY DVWC AEUBU OUXEV OM

The first problem area – QRQ.

If you dropped only one Q, which one would it be? Should you drop both Qs? That just doesn't seem consistent. If both were to be dropped, why not just pair up the second Q with a different KRYPTOS letter?

There is yet another possibility. The first Q corresponds to our mystery "T" that may or may not be part of the text. If that Q wasn't there, then there is no ambiguity in this situation.

So, rethinking the original clue, let's include the T, making the clue KR SOT YP and simultaneously eliminating our current problem.

The second problem – KQQ.

Well, if our rule for the placement of the nulls is correct, there does have to be a method of handling a natural Q or Z that appears in the text and just happens to be next to a KRYPTOS letter. (Not an unlikely event considering that many of the letters in KRYPTOS have a reasonably high frequency).

The most straightforward technique would seem to be simply placing one of the nulls next to the natural pair. This way the null Q would be dropped, while the real Q remains.

Note that this would require that the null Q be placed adjacent to the natural Q (as in KQQ), not adjacent to the KRYPTOS letter (as in QKQ). The latter would leave an ambiguity that could result in either KQ or QK remaining.

The final text – prior to the transposition.

Applying these guesses to the two problem areas we are left with the following message:

?ISUI YIABU FSNIF CSSRF MKLLJ MHAEN
RLNDL NNXET TRODE FUWCO RCHSH KQGTJ
ERAW E TYDVW CAEUB UOUXE VOM

And a "key" to work with of:

KR SOT YP

Of course I could be wrong. ☺